The Chattanooga Guides Series

# Museums & Exhibits in Chattanooga, TN - 21 Locations

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**Geo coverage:** Chattanooga, TN and day trips (Lookout Mountain, Fort Oglethorpe GA, South Pittsburg TN, Dayton TN, Cherry Log GA, Chatsworth GA, Calhoun GA)

#museums #interactive

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This guide covers *21* museums and exhibits in Chattanooga and nearby. The listings span art, history, science, and interactive attractions.

Chattanooga sits at the center of several major American history threads. Cherokee displacement, Civil War battles, African American cultural history along 9th Street, and industrial heritage all have dedicated exhibits here. The art options include a nationally recognized fine art museum on the

downtown bluff and a free 33 acre sculpture park in North Chattanooga.

Ten spots are in or adjacent to downtown. The Aquarium, Medal of Honor Heritage Center, and Classic Arcade Pinball Museum are all near the riverfront. Hunter Museum and Bessie Smith Cultural Center are each a short walk from there. Creative Discovery Museum is a few blocks further. A full downtown day is achievable on foot.

Several entries are a short drive outside the city. Chickamauga Battlefield is 15 minutes into Georgia. The guide reaches Dayton, Chatsworth, and Calhoun, all within 45 minutes. Chief Vann House and New Echota make a strong combined day trip.

The filters are worth using. *Kids* shows five spots built around hands-on family experiences. *Free admission* narrows to no-cost options, including Sculpture Fields and the UTC Observatory's weekly Star Parties.

If there is a museum or exhibit worth adding, send an email. Hours and admission prices change. Confirm before you go.

*Map View Of The Museums & Exhibits Featured Below*

## Type:

Art | History | Science & Nature | Interactive

## Format:

Indoor | Outdoor | Free admission | Good for kids

← Try Me

## Location:

Downtown | Day trip

## 1. Tennessee Aquarium .

Two buildings on the Tennessee River waterfront, connected by a pedestrian bridge. River Journey covers freshwater ecosystems from Appalachian cove forest down to the Gulf: river otters, alligators, turtles, paddlefish, and gulf sturgeon. Ocean Journey covers saltwater: a butterfly garden, penguins, sharks, stingrays, and reef fish. Touch pools in both buildings. Ocean Journey's newest gallery, Scuttlebutt Reef, opened in 2026. IMAX theater on site. Weekday mornings are dramatically less crowded than weekend afternoons.

Google Maps Website

#indoor #science #kids #downtown

## 2. Hunter Museum of American Art .

Three connected buildings on an 80 foot bluff above the Tennessee River: a 1904 Classical Revival mansion, a 1975 Brutalist addition, and a 2005 contemporary glass wing. Nearly 3,000 works spanning American art from the colonial period to today, with rotating exhibitions alongside the permanent collection. Sculpture garden outside. Active programming and lecture series throughout the year.

Google Maps Website

#indoor #art #downtown

## 3. Creative Discovery Museum .

Four floors of hands on exhibits at the corner of Chestnut and 4th. Permanent lineup includes a multi pod treehouse, STEM Zone with robotics, ArtSpace, Tennessee RiverPlay water exhibit, and Little FarmHouse for toddlers. Built for kids through middle school age, not just the smallest ones. Weekday mornings are dramatically less crowded than weekend afternoons.

Google Maps Website

#indoor #science #art #interactive #kids #downtown

## 4. National Medal of Honor Heritage Center .

At 2 W Aquarium Way, steps from the Aquarium. Traces the Medal of Honor from its Civil War origins through Afghanistan and Iraq across personal stories, artifacts, and interactive displays from every major American conflict. Smaller than the Aquarium next door, compact and rarely crowded. Free admission for active military and veterans.

Google Maps Website

#indoor #history #downtown

## 5. Bessie Smith Cultural Center .

Named for Chattanooga native and blues icon Bessie Smith. At 200 E Martin Luther King Blvd, newly renovated exhibits use video and interactive technology to walk through African American history in the city: from antebellum and slavery

through the famed 9th Street jazz era, civil rights, and the present. Rotating art exhibits alongside the permanent collection. Closed weekends. Shares a building with Bessie Smith Hall, a live music venue.

Google Maps Website

#indoor #history #art #downtown

## 6. Sculpture Fields at Montague Park .

33 acre park in North Chattanooga with large scale contemporary sculptures spread across open fields. Free, no tickets, no schedule. Work rotates as artists loan and install pieces across the grounds. The Tennessee Valley Railroad runs a lunch excursion that stops here. Easy to combine with Coolidge Park or a morning outdoors day.

Google Maps Website

#outdoor #art #free #north-chattanooga

## 7. International Towing & Recovery Museum .

Only museum in the country dedicated to the towing industry, at 3315 Broad St. 24 historic wreckers on the floor spanning 1913 to 2002, including an original Ernest Holmes Sr. Model C from 1913, the first commercially produced wrecker, built right here in Chattanooga. Hall of Fame wall. Compact but dense. Worth an hour if you have any interest in industrial history or working vehicles.

Google Maps Website

#indoor #history #southside

## 8. Tennessee Valley Railroad Museum .

Steam and diesel locomotives in working order, spread across the yard at 4119 Cromwell Rd. Standard excursion runs a 6 mile roundtrip through the yard and into an 1858 tunnel. Also runs dinner trains, Civil War excursions to Chickamauga, and a lunch train that stops at Sculpture Fields. Polar Express runs December. The car barn and restoration yard are worth seeing up close.

Google Maps Website

#indoor #outdoor #history #kids #east-chattanooga

## 9. Chickamauga Battlefield Visitor Center .

About 15 minutes from downtown in Fort Oglethorpe, GA. The oldest and largest Civil War park in the country: 5,000 acres and over 600 monuments. Visitor center has a museum with artifacts, a detailed relief map, and a 26 minute orientation film. The battlefield runs as a self guided driving or walking tour. The Fuller Gun Collection inside is one of the largest Civil War small arms collections in the country. Budget at least 2 hours, more if you walk any of the trails.

Google Maps Website

#indoor #outdoor #history #near-georgia

## 10. Classic Arcade Pinball Museum .

One price, unlimited play on everything in the building. Pinball machines from the 1940s to today plus classic arcade games, around 40 machines on the floor at any time. Adults run about $20, kids $16. Downtown at 409 Broad St. Works as an afternoon drop-in or an evening stop after dinner.

Google Maps Website

#indoor #interactive #kids #downtown

## 11. Ruby Falls .

Underground waterfall 1,120 feet below Lookout Mountain, reached by elevator. Guided tours walk about a half mile through cave formations to a 145 foot waterfall, discovered in 1928. No self guided option. Tours take about 45 to 60 minutes and run continuously. Weekends and summer dates book out in advance. The entrance building has a lookout tower with mountain views included in the ticket.

Google Maps Website

#indoor #science #lookout-mountain

## 12. Lodge Museum of Cast Iron .

About 35 minutes west of Chattanooga in South Pittsburg, TN, at 220 E 3rd St. Lodge has made cast iron cookware here since 1896 and the museum covers the full production process, the role of cast iron in Southern food culture (developed with the Southern Foodways Alliance), and a debunking exhibit that tackles cast iron myths including the soap debate. Centerpiece is an 18 foot cast iron skillet. $5 admission, free for kids under 5. Big Bad Breakfast operates inside the building. The Lodge flagship store is attached.

Google Maps Website

#indoor #history #kids #south-pittsburg

## 13. Expedition: Bigfoot! .

In Cherry Log, GA off GA-515 between Ellijay and Blue Ridge, about an hour from Chattanooga. The nation's largest collection of Bigfoot footprint casts, plus life-size creature exhibits, audio recordings of alleged encounters, and interactive displays covering sighting reports from across North America. Self guided, takes about 45 to 60 minutes. $8 admission. Takes itself seriously enough to be informative, loosely enough to be fun.

Google Maps Website

#indoor #interactive #north-georgia

## 14. Scopes Trial Museum .

About 40 minutes north of Chattanooga in Dayton, TN, inside the Rhea County Courthouse where the 1925 Scopes Trial took place. John Scopes was prosecuted here for teaching evolution in what became one of the most covered trials in American history. The courtroom is intact. Museum holds the original broadcast microphone, trial records, photographs, and an audiovisual history of the case. Free admission.

Google Maps Website

#indoor #history #dayton

## 15. Chief Vann House State Historic Site .

About 45 minutes from Chattanooga in Chatsworth, GA. Built in 1804 by Cherokee Chief James Vann, described at the time as the finest private residence in the Cherokee Nation. Federal style mansion on what was a thousand acre plantation. Guided tours cover Cherokee history, the plantation economy, and the forced removal that followed. One of the few surviving antebellum structures built and owned by a Cherokee citizen.

Google Maps Website

#indoor #history #chatsworth

## 16. New Echota State Historic Site .

About 45 minutes south of Chattanooga near Calhoun, GA. Former capital of the Cherokee Nation, where the 1835 treaty authorizing the Trail of Tears was signed. Reconstructed

buildings include the council house, Supreme Court building, and the print shop where the Cherokee Phoenix was printed in the Cherokee syllabary. A small museum covers Cherokee governance and the removal. Gets far less foot traffic than its history warrants.

Google Maps Website

#indoor #outdoor #history #calhoun

## 17. Songbirds Guitar & Pop Culture Museum .

Vintage guitars, amps, and pedals at 1407A Market Street, from what was once one of the largest private guitar collections in the country. Much of that collection has since been sold, so the display is smaller now. Viewing is mostly tied to concerts and events. Songbirds runs as a nonprofit today, with youth music programs and a busy live music venue. Check the event schedule before you go.

Google Maps Website

#indoor #interactive #art #downtown

## 18. Coker Museum .

130+ vintage vehicles at 1309 Chestnut St: cars, trucks, buses, motorcycles, and aircraft spanning significant eras of American automotive history, assembled from Corky Coker's personal collection. Working restoration garage on site gives a live look at preservation in progress. Self-guided, with QR codes on the

vehicles linking to video of Coker walking through the stories behind each piece. Open Tuesday through Saturday.

Google Maps Website

#indoor #history #interactive #downtown

## 19. Clarence T. Jones Observatory .

Digital planetarium on the UTC campus at 10 N Tuxedo Ave. Public Star Parties run most Sunday evenings during the school year: gates open at 6:30pm, planetarium shows every half hour from 7 to 9pm, telescope viewing after. Free admission. This is schedule dependent. Nothing is open outside of Star Party nights, so check the UTC calendar before making it the plan.

Google Maps Website

#indoor #science #free #downtown

## 20. ICA Chattanooga (Institute of Contemporary Art at UTC) .

Free public gallery for contemporary art on the UTC campus at 752 Vine St, inside the Fine Arts Center. Exhibitions lean toward artists working in and about the South. Student-curated shows and BFA thesis work round out the calendar. Small enough to see in under an hour, and rarely crowded. Closed Wednesday and Sunday, so check the hours first.

Google Maps Website

#indoor #art #free #downtown

## 21. Reflection Riding Arboretum & Nature Center .

317 acres of gardens, native plant trails, and live animals at the base of Lookout Mountain, 400 Garden Rd. Roughly 15 miles of trails wind through the arboretum. The nature center keeps a pack of endangered red wolves, bred through the national Red Wolf Species Survival Plan. A treehouse and animal habitats make it an easy half day with kids. Open Tuesday through Saturday, about $10 for adults and $7 for kids and seniors.

Google Maps Website

#outdoor #science #lookout-mountain

Downtown Chattanooga lets you combine several museums in a single day without moving your car. The Aquarium and Medal of Honor Heritage Center are two blocks apart. Hunter Museum is a 10 minute walk. Songbirds is on Main Street heading south. Build the route around opening times, since Creative Discovery and the Classic Arcade are busier on weekend afternoons.

For spots outside the city, plan around one anchor. Chickamauga is a half day minimum. Chief Vann House and New Echota together make a full Georgia day trip. The Lodge Museum works as an add-on to anything going toward Nashville on I-24.

This guide is updated regularly. If a spot has closed or changed admission, send a note. The same for any exhibit we missed. For

live performances at historic venues, see the Chattanooga performing arts guide.

# FAQ.

## Which museums are in downtown Chattanooga?

Ten entries in this guide are in or adjacent to downtown: the Tennessee Aquarium, Hunter Museum of American Art, Creative Discovery Museum, National Medal of Honor Heritage Center, Bessie Smith Cultural Center, Classic Arcade Pinball Museum, Songbirds Guitar Museum, Coker Museum, ICA Chattanooga, and the Clarence T. Jones Observatory on the UTC campus.

## What are the best museums for kids in Chattanooga?

Five spots are built around hands-on family experiences: Tennessee Aquarium (touch pools, IMAX), Creative Discovery Museum (four floors for kids through middle school), Tennessee Valley Railroad Museum (train rides), Classic Arcade Pinball Museum (unlimited play, kids pricing), and Lodge Museum of Cast Iron ($5 admission, free for kids under 5).

## Are there free museums in Chattanooga?

Sculpture Fields at Montague Park is free and open any time with no tickets required. The Clarence T. Jones Observatory runs free Star Parties on most Sunday evenings during the school year. Chickamauga Battlefield Visitor Center is also free as a National Park Service site.

## How long does the Tennessee Aquarium take?

Budget at least 2 to 3 hours for both buildings. River Journey and Ocean Journey are connected by a pedestrian bridge. Weekday mornings are significantly less crowded than weekend afternoons. Add 45 to 90 minutes if you plan on an IMAX show.

## What are good museum day trips from Chattanooga?

Chickamauga Battlefield (15 min into Georgia) is the closest major site outside the city. Chief Vann House (45 min) and New Echota (45 min) cover Cherokee history and combine well as a single Georgia day. Scopes Trial Museum in Dayton (40 min north) is free and rarely crowded. Lodge Museum of Cast Iron in South Pittsburg (35 min west) is worth the drive.

## Is there a museum about Chattanooga music history?

Songbirds at 1407A Market Street displays vintage guitars spanning decades of American music, though much of its original collection has been sold and viewing is mostly tied to events. The Bessie Smith Cultural Center documents African American cultural history in Chattanooga, including the 9th Street jazz era named for Chattanooga native Bessie Smith.

# Other Guides.

## Guided Tours

City history, ghost, kayak, cave

## Performance Arts

Theater, symphony, comedy

## Outdoor Adventures

Hiking, kayaking, climbing

## Live Music

Venues, festivals, local artists

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